

Grace, Faith, and Works: Harmonizing Paul and James on Salvation

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Introduction

The relationship between faith and works has long been a subject of theological discussion, particularly in light of the writings of Paul and James. Paul declares that salvation is by grace through faith, apart from works (**Ephesians 2:8–9**), while James declares that “faith without works is dead” (**James 2:26**).

Are these two perspectives contradictory, or do they present a unified truth?

They are not contradictory. Paul and James address different errors and emphasize different aspects of saving faith. Paul confronts the attempt to establish righteousness before God through human works. James confronts the claim to possess faith when there is no evidence of that faith in the life of the believer.

Paul explains how a sinner is justified before God. James explains how genuine faith is demonstrated as real.

Together, their teaching presents a complete picture of salvation: **we are saved by God's grace through faith, and the faith that saves is a living faith that produces works.**

¹ *Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations in this paper are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).*

I. Paul: Salvation by Grace Through Faith

Paul teaches that salvation is entirely a work of God's grace, received through faith rather than earned by human effort.

“For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast.” — Ephesians 2:8–9

Paul further declares:

“For we maintain that a man is justified by faith apart from works of the law.” — Romans 3:28

The point is unmistakable. A sinner cannot establish righteousness before God through morality, religious activity, law-keeping, or any other human achievement.

Justification is God's gracious declaration that the sinner who trusts in Christ is righteous on the basis of Christ's righteousness, not his own.

Paul makes the same argument from Abraham:

“For what does the Scripture say? ‘Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness.’” — Romans 4:3

Paul then draws the conclusion:

“Now to the one who works, wages are not credited as a gift, but as an obligation. However, to the one who does not work, but believes in Him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is credited as righteousness.” — Romans 4:4–5

Paul is therefore addressing the **basis of justification**. Salvation cannot be earned. It is received by faith as God's gracious gift.

II. James: The Necessity of Works as Evidence of Faith

James addresses a different problem.

A person may claim to have faith while demonstrating no corresponding change in life. James asks:

“What good is it, my brothers, if someone claims to have faith, but has no deeds? Can such faith save him?” — James 2:14

James then states:

“So too, faith by itself, if it does not result in action, is dead.” — James 2:17

James is not teaching that human works earn salvation. Rather, he exposes the emptiness of a faith that exists only as an intellectual profession or verbal claim.

A person can say that he believes, but genuine faith reveals itself through the life that follows.

James therefore says:

“But someone will say, ‘You have faith and I have deeds.’ Show me your faith without deeds, and I will show you my faith by my deeds.” — James 2:18

Works are visible evidence of an invisible faith.

James is confronting **dead faith**—a profession that produces no evidence of spiritual life.

A Practical Example

Consider a man who professes that he trusted Christ as a child. Yet throughout his adult life, he is characterized by persistent, unrepentant sin, showing little evidence of love for Christ, obedience to God's Word, repentance, or a desire for holiness. After his death, a relative points to his childhood profession of faith as evidence of his salvation.

Can such a profession alone provide confidence that his faith was genuine?

James directs us to examine the evidence. A verbal profession, by itself, is not the same as living faith. He asks, “Can such faith save him?” (**James 2:14**), and declares that “faith by itself, if it does not result in action, is dead” (**James 2:17**).

The point is not that we can determine with certainty whether another person was saved. **Only God knows the heart.** Jesus warned against assuming the role of final judge (**Matthew 7:1–5**), while also instructing His followers to recognize people by their fruit (**Matthew 7:16–20**).

The point is that **a profession of faith is not itself the evidence James is talking about. The evidence is the life that follows.**

A profession of faith is a testimony of what a person says he believes.

A transformed life is evidence that the faith is living.

III. Paul and James: Different Questions, One Gospel

The apparent contradiction becomes clearer when we recognize the different questions Paul and James are answering.

Paul asks:

How is a sinner made right with God?

His answer: **By grace through faith, apart from works.**

James asks:

How can genuine faith be recognized as genuine?

His answer: **By the works that faith produces.**

Paul confronts **legalism**—the attempt to establish righteousness through human works.

James confronts **empty profession**—the claim to possess faith without the evidence of a transformed life.

Paul says:

“For we maintain that a man is justified by faith apart from works of the law.” — Romans 3:28

James says:

“As you can see, a man is justified by his deeds and not by faith alone.” — James 2:24

At first glance, these statements appear contradictory. But James is not describing a second method by which sinners earn acceptance before God. His argument concerns the **demonstration or vindication of genuine faith.**

IV. Abraham: Faith Demonstrated by Works

Abraham provides the clearest biblical example of how faith and works relate.

Genesis records:

“And Abram believed the LORD, and it was credited to him as righteousness.” — Genesis 15:6

Paul uses this passage to establish justification by faith.

Abraham believed God's promise, and God counted his faith as righteousness.

Years later, Abraham demonstrated that faith through his willingness to offer Isaac in obedience to God's command (**Genesis 22**).

James explains:

“You see that his faith was working with his actions, and his faith was perfected by what he did.”
— James 2:22

James then refers back to Genesis 15:6:

“And the Scripture was fulfilled that says, ‘Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness,’ and he was called a friend of God.” — James 2:23

This is significant.

Abraham's obedience in Genesis 22 did not replace the faith by which he had been counted righteous in Genesis 15. Rather, his obedience demonstrated the reality and maturity of the faith he already possessed.

Faith was the root; obedience was the fruit.

Abraham's works did not create his faith. They revealed it.

V. Faith and Works: Root and Fruit

The relationship between faith and works can be summarized as:

- **Faith is the root of salvation** — we are justified before God by faith (**Romans 5:1**).
- **Works are the fruit of salvation** — the natural evidence of a transformed life (**Ephesians 2:10**).

Works are the outward evidence of the inward change that has taken place in the heart of the born-again believer. They do not produce the new life; they reveal it.

Paul writes:

“Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” — 2 Corinthians 5:17

The transformed life that follows is expressed through the good works God has prepared for His people to do:

“For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life.” — Ephesians 2:10

James makes the same point from another direction:

“I will show you my faith by my deeds.” — James 2:18

Works are therefore not the root of salvation but the visible evidence that genuine faith has taken root within.

Jesus taught that a tree is known by its fruit (**Matthew 7:16–20**), emphasizing that genuine spiritual life will manifest itself outwardly.

A faith devoid of works is dead, lacking the vitality that characterizes genuine faith.

Faith and works are not adversaries but partners. Works flow as the natural expression of genuine faith, not as a basis for justification. Faith draws life from God's grace; works reveal the vitality of that faith—not as the cause of salvation but as its natural outgrowth.

Faith never stands alone. Genuine saving faith produces evidence in the life of the believer. As Charles Spurgeon emphasized:

“We believe that men are saved by faith, alone, but not by a faith which is alone.”

Works do not contribute to the basis of our justification; they demonstrate that the faith by which we have been justified is living and genuine.

VI. The New Birth Produces a Changed Life

The connection between faith and works becomes even clearer when we consider the doctrine of the new birth.

Salvation is not merely a change in one's legal status before God. The person who comes to Christ is spiritually transformed.

Paul writes:

“Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation.” — 2 Corinthians 5:17

This new life produces new desires and new behavior. The believer is not saved *because* he produces good works; he produces good works *because he has been saved*.

The order is crucial:

Grace → Faith → New Birth → Transformation → Works

Works therefore function as evidence of the new life God has created within the believer. This is why James can insist that faith without works is dead. A dead faith cannot save because it is not genuine saving faith.

VII. Faith Produces Love, Obedience, and Perseverance

True faith is not merely intellectual agreement with facts about Jesus Christ. Saving faith involves personal reliance upon Christ and produces a changed relationship with God and with others.

Even demons believe certain truths about God:

“You believe that God is one. Good for you! Even the demons believe that—and shudder.” — James 2:19

Paul writes:

“For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision nor uncircumcision has any value. What counts is a new creation.” — Galatians 6:15

And again:

“The only thing that counts is faith expressing itself through love.” — Galatians 5:6

True faith therefore manifests itself in:

- love,
- obedience,
- perseverance,
- repentance,
- good works,
- and a growing desire to please God.

These things do not purchase salvation. They demonstrate the reality of salvation.

VIII. Justification, Sanctification, and Glorification

The harmony between Paul and James becomes even clearer when salvation is viewed in its biblical fullness.

We have been justified

The believer has been declared righteous through faith in Christ.

“Therefore, since we have been justified through faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.” — Romans 5:1

Justification is God's work and rests entirely upon Christ.

We are being sanctified

The believer is progressively transformed by the Holy Spirit.

“For this is the will of God, your sanctification...” — 1 Thessalonians 4:3

Good works belong here. They are the fruit of the new life God has already given.

We will be glorified

God will ultimately complete the work He has begun.

“He who began a good work in you will continue to perfect it until the day of Christ Jesus.” — Philippians 1:6

Thus:

Justification — Christ's righteousness is credited to us.

Sanctification — The believer is increasingly transformed into the likeness of Christ.

Glorification — Christ's work in us is completed.

All three are ultimately the work of God's grace.

Conclusion

Paul and James stand on different sides of the same doorway to salvation—Paul highlighting the entrance by faith, James emphasizing the life that flows from it. Paul focuses on the means of justification before God: by grace through faith alone. James underscores the evidence of that faith: a life transformed in obedience and good works. Far from being in conflict, their teachings together form a complete portrait of genuine, saving faith. As James declares, “For as the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without works is dead also” (**James 2:26**).

True saving faith is not static but living. It produces love, obedience, perseverance, and good works—not as the basis of our salvation, but as the evidence that God's transforming grace is at work within us.

We are saved by grace through faith, and the faith that saves is never barren.

Works are the outward evidence of the inward change that has taken place in the heart of the born-again believer. They do not produce the new life; they reveal it.

The doorway is entered by faith, but what is seen on the other side is a life increasingly transformed by God's grace.

Grace is the source. Faith is the means. Works are the evidence.

This is the harmony between Paul and James: **we are justified by faith, transformed by grace, and called to live out the reality of that faith through obedience, which is demonstrated in the resulting good works.**